Chapter Five

Stalemate

"The Israeli-Palestinian conflict is a tragedy; it is a clash between right and right."

—Amos Oz

While the IDF was engaged in fighting the Arab Legion and Egyptian forces, three brigades of the Iraqi Army launched an attack over the Jordan River. Just like the Egyptian offensive, this made far less rapid progress than had been expected. First, the Iraqi forces attacked a Jewish settlement at Gesher, but resistance proved much more stubborn and effective than expected. The Iraqis were forced to withdraw to an area within three Arab settlements in Palestine: Nablus, Jenin, and Tulkarm. On May 28, a counter-attack by the IDF led to three days of heavy fighting around Jenin. Both sides suffered heavy casualties. Although the IDF was unable to take the town, the Iraqi advance was effectively halted, and from the end of May, Iraqi forces in Palestine switched to a defensive posture in order to hold the small amount of territory they had been able to occupy.

Syrian forces had in the meantime begun their attack on May 14, and by the following day, they were engaged in attacks on several Jewish settlements on the shores of the Sea of Galilee. Here, they encountered fierce resistance, first from local armed militia units and, later, from the IDF as its forces arrived in the area. On May 21, Syrian tanks mounted an attack on the kibbutz of Degania Alef but were halted by the use of Molotov cocktails (improvised anti-tank weapons). The Syrian forces withdrew to prepare for another attack the following day but found themselves under bombardment by IDF forces using artillery provided by France, the first use of artillery by the IDF during the war.

On June 10, Syrian forces mounted an attack on another Jewish settlement called Mishmar HaYarden. While they were able to occupy this settlement, casualties caused by fierce resistance